

Burial Guide

What to do when a death occurs, understanding your burial options, service types, death certificates, and what to expect throughout the process.

FIRST STEPS • BURIAL OPTIONS • SERVICE TYPES • PRINTABLE

SECTION 1

What to Do When a Death Occurs

The first hours and days — step by step

Here's what needs to happen, and the order it happens in. You don't have to sort all of it out at once — we go through each step with you. If you're planning ahead and haven't chosen between burial and cremation yet, the [Cremation or Burial guide](#) compares the two side by side.

1

Contact Bonney Watson

Call us at **206-242-1787** (available 24/7). We will arrange to bring your loved one into our care. If the death occurs at home under hospice, the hospice nurse will call us on your behalf.

2

Gather Important Documents

We'll need the decedent's legal name, Social Security number, date of birth, and veteran status. If they have a pre-plan, locate the paperwork — it has most of this information.

3

Meet with Us

We'll set up a time to meet, usually within a day or two. That's where we go through the type of service, the casket, cemetery property, and the rest of the details.

4

Select a Service Date

Most burial services take place 5–10 days after death, allowing time for family to travel and for obituary publication. We coordinate with the cemetery, clergy, and any other parties.

5

Finalize Details

Flowers, music, pallbearers, readings, photo displays, obituary wording — we help with all of it. Take on as much or as little of it as you want to.

If a Pre-Plan Exists

If your loved one pre-planned, **most of the decisions are already made**. Locate the pre-plan documents and bring them to your arrangement meeting. We'll review the selections and handle everything from there.

SECTION 2

Burial vs. Entombment

Understanding the two primary forms of interment

Traditional Ground Burial

IN-GROUND INTERMENT

The casket is placed in a grave at the cemetery and sealed with a concrete vault. The grave is marked with a flush granite marker or, in select sections, an upright monument.

- Single or companion (side-by-side) spaces available
- Concrete outer burial container required
- Flush marker in most sections; upright in select areas
- Endowment care included — perpetual grounds maintenance
- Multiple sections with different settings and pricing

Entombment (Mausoleum)

ABOVE-GROUND INTERMENT

The casket is placed in a mausoleum crypt — an above-ground structure with individual sealed compartments. An alternative for families who prefer above-ground placement.

- Climate-protected, above-ground resting place
- No outer burial container required
- Engraved granite or bronze faceplate
- Limited availability at Washington Memorial Park
- Single and companion crypts

The vast majority of families at Washington Memorial Park choose **traditional ground burial**. The cemetery has over 20 sections, each with a different landscape and price range. We can walk you through what's available and help you find the right spot.

SECTION 3

Types of Services

What each one involves, and when families tend to choose it

Viewing & Funeral Service

TRADITIONAL SERVICE

A formal viewing (visitation) followed by a funeral service, typically at a chapel or church, and then a procession to the cemetery for graveside committal. This is what most people picture when they think of a funeral. Families choose it when a lot of people will want to come, or when seeing them one last time matters.

- Embalming and preparation for viewing
- Viewing period for family and friends
- Formal funeral service with clergy or celebrant
- Procession to cemetery
- Graveside committal with final prayers

Graveside Service

SIMPLER & MORE INTIMATE

The service is held at the graveside rather than in a chapel. Often shorter, with the casket present at the grave. No separate viewing or procession. Families choose this when the group is small, or when a full chapel service is more than they want.

- Service held at the cemetery gravesite
- Typically 30–45 minutes
- More intimate gathering
- Clergy, readings, and music as desired
- Casket present at graveside

Memorial Service

FLEXIBLE & PERSONAL

A service held after the burial has already taken place. The body is not present — photos, keepsakes, and stories carry it instead. Can be held anywhere. This is common when family has to travel, or when it takes a while to get everyone in the same place.

- Held after burial is complete
- Body not present — focus on memories
- Can be held at chapel, home, or any venue
- Flexible timing — days, weeks, or months later
- Often called a "celebration of life"

Private Family Burial

QUIET & PRIVATE

A small, private gathering at the graveside with only immediate family. No formal service, no public viewing. Some families follow with a larger memorial at a later date.

- Immediate family only
- Brief graveside gathering
- No formal service required
- Can be followed by a public memorial later
- Most private option

Death Certificates

How many you need and what they're used for

A **certified death certificate** is an official government document required to settle your loved one's affairs. You'll need more copies than you might expect — most families order **8–12 certified copies**.

We file the death certificate with the state and order certified copies on your behalf. Each certified copy costs **\$25** from the state of Washington. It's much easier (and faster) to order enough copies upfront than to request additional copies later.

You will need a certified copy for **each** institution that requires one. Most institutions will not accept photocopies.

WHO NEEDS A CERTIFIED COPY

- **Banks** — each bank, one copy each
- **Insurance companies** — life, health, auto
- **Social Security Administration**
- **VA / military benefits**
- **Retirement / pension plans**
- **Real estate / title companies**
- **Vehicle title transfer (DOL)**
- **Attorney / probate court**
- **Employer / HR department**
- **Credit card companies**

SECTION 5

What to Expect

The process from arrangement to interment

First Call

You call us (24/7). We arrange transfer of your loved one into our care within hours.

Arrangement Meeting

Meet with us to make selections: service type, casket, cemetery property, and details.

Obituary & Notices

We help draft the obituary and submit to newspapers or online platforms as you wish.

Service Planning

Music, readings, photos, flowers, pallbearers — we help coordinate every element.

Viewing & Service

The viewing and/or funeral service, held at the chapel, church, or graveside as planned.

Procession

A formal procession from chapel to cemetery, with escort and family vehicles.

Graveside Committal

Final prayers and committal at the graveside. The casket is lowered after the family departs.

Marker & Memorialization

After interment, we begin the marker order. Granite markers typically take 10–14 weeks to complete.

SECTION 6

Caskets, Vaults & Markers

The merchandise included in a burial arrangement

Caskets

OVER 200 OPTIONS

We carry over 200 caskets in metal and wood, from simple and dignified to highly personalized. Prices range from approximately \$1,130 to \$12,000+.

- **Metal caskets** — 141 options in 5 price tiers
- **Wood caskets** — 63 options in 5 price tiers
- View our interactive **Metal Casket Guide** and **Wood Casket Guide**

Outer Burial Containers

REQUIRED FOR GROUND BURIAL

Washington Memorial Park requires a concrete outer burial container (vault) for all ground burials. This protects the casket and prevents the ground from settling.

- **Burial vault** — sealed concrete or metal, premium protection
- Required by cemetery, not by state law

Every burial also includes a **flush granite marker** (in most sections). View our interactive **Granite Marker Guide** for sizes, pricing, stone colors, and photo portrait options.



Serving Seattle families since 1868 · Washington Memorial Park

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